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Playable Systems: Game co-design for systemic insight

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Current methods in systemic design are largely dependent on elaboration and exploration of complexity in a variety of settings. Most commonly, methods that combine system mapping from the systems science and engineering community with a variety of participatory and co-design techniques aimed at maximising stakeholder engagement are employed. However, systems mapping is only one step in addressing systemic problems. In engineering, the next steps are often the development, deployment, and testing of designed systems. However, where social systems are concerned, interventions of this kind are not so simple.

Borrowing another technique from engineering, *simulation*, as a faster and more ethical method of testing interventions in social systems is a potential next step. Games are an ideal way of introducing simulation into systemic design. Games are low-fidelity simulations and have a rich history and connection to systems thinking. Game Design is also its own unique subdiscipline in design with co-design and prototyping methods of its own. This workshop demonstrates the use of a Playable Systems Approach, a material-procedural facilitation approach for generating systemic insights and prototyping solutions through co-designing multi-stakeholder games.

KEYWORDS: game design, systemic design, design methods, toolkits, playable systems

RSD TOPIC(S): Cases & Practice, Mapping & Modelling, Methods & Methodology

Description

The Playable Systems Approach is a new development at the intersection of systems and design that emphasises capturing the dynamics of complex problems. Where systems mapping creates a visual representation of a complex problem, emphasising the structure and relations of system components, the Playable Systems Approach leverages the embodied nature of play as a means of generating systemic insights. As the name suggests, the approach is based on game co-design techniques used to prototype tabletop and digital games, as well as low-fidelity prototyping and simulation. Benefits of the Playable Systems Approach include the surfacing of stakeholder assumptions and implicit conflicts, the creation of “Brave Spaces” for bold or unorthodox ideas, and the ability to test low-fidelity interventions, among others.

During the workshop, we introduce participants to the rationale behind the Playable Systems Approach, discuss its strengths and weaknesses, and explain the steps behind planning and facilitating a Playable Systems workshop on a topic. After introducing the contents of a typical Playable Systems GameKit the organisers walk participants through a step-by-step example of how to deploy a kit in a workshop setting.

Topics covered

The workshop includes an introduction to game design and low-fidelity simulation, including key terminology and references.

This workshop is informative and useful to anyone looking for additional facilitation approaches to aid their systemic design practice.

Objectives

Participants receive a conceptual introduction to the Playable Systems Approach, a how-to explanation for planning and facilitating a Playable Systems Workshop and descriptive examples of the contents of a Playable Systems GameKit. A typical Playable Systems workshop requires at least a half-day and considerable planning, so participants should be aware that this is NOT an example workshop but more of a meta-workshop to demonstrate the methodology and its possibilities for those who want to facilitate their own workshops or learn more about the technique.

Agenda

1. Introduction to the Method (10mins)
2. Preparing for a Workshop (10mins)
3. The GameKit (10mins)
4. The Workbook (10mins)
5. Walkthrough (30mins)
6. Discussion (20mins)

Facilitators/organisers

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Evan's research examines topics in computing and design through a systems lens, including extended reality, education, sustainability, and human behaviour. Much of his work emerges from the Iteration Lab, a domain-agnostic project triage studio he co-directs with J.R. Osborn. Iteration Lab researches and deploys iterative and divination methods to help clients make decisions about the future of their projects, large or small.

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